
Handling & Release

Do this right and it costs you thirty seconds

A released fish that dies anyway was not released

Most fish you catch on these lakes go back — everything under 14 inches, every bass out of season, and anything you simply do not need. Whether those fish survive is decided almost entirely in the sixty seconds after they reach the boat, and almost all of it is under your control.

The rules, in order of how much they matter

- 1. Keep it in the water** Every second out of water is a second not breathing. Unhook a fish in the net, in the water, whenever you can. If you want a photograph, get the camera ready *first*, then lift.
- 2. Wet your hands** Dry hands, a dry towel and a dry deck strip the protective slime coat, and the raw patch underneath is where infection and fungus start. Wet hands, wet net, wet everything.
- 3. Support the weight** One hand under the belly on anything over a couple of pounds. Holding a heavy fish vertically by the jaw stretches and tears the joint and the organs behind it. A bass under about two pounds is fine held by the lower lip; above that, use two hands.
- 4. Never touch the gills** Gill filaments are exposed blood vessels. A fish bleeding from the gills is a fish that will die, whatever it looks like when it swims off. No fingers under the plate, ever.
- 5. Cut the line on a deep hook** If the hook is in the throat or gut, **do not dig for it**. Cut the line as close as you can and let the fish go. A left hook rusts out or is expelled; a torn oesophagus does not heal.
- 6. Revive it properly** Hold it upright, facing into any current, or move it gently *forward* through the water. Never sweep it back and forth — water runs the wrong way through the gills and it does harm rather than good. Let go when it kicks free on its own.

What makes it worse

Factor	What to do about it
Warm water	Above roughly 75 °F a fish recovers slowly and its oxygen demand is high. In July and August, keep handling times short, revive longer, and consider moving to a different lesson for the day if fish are clearly struggling. Pike are the most fragile of the lot in warm water.
Deep water	A fish pulled quickly from more than about 25–30 ft may suffer barotrauma: the swim bladder over-expands and it cannot swim down. Signs are bloating, bulging eyes, or a fish that floats on its side. If you are catching fish deep and intend to release them, fish shallower or keep what you catch.
Long fight	Playing a fish to complete exhaustion on light line is hard on it. Use tackle heavy enough to land the fish quickly.
Treble hooks	Three times the chance of a bad hookset. Crush the barbs, or replace a set of trebles with single hooks on baits you use around fish you will release.
Handling a pike	Backward-facing teeth and a fish strong enough to thrash. Jaw spreaders and long pliers, every time. <i>see the Northern Pike sheet</i>

Keep a fish properly, too

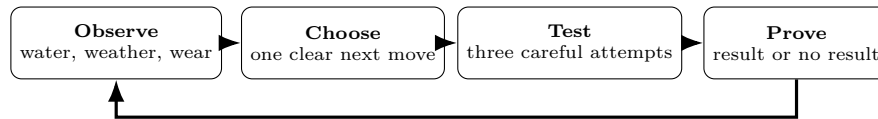
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| Decide early | Kill it or release it in the first minute. A fish kept on a stringer for two hours and then released is worse off than one killed immediately, and it is worse eating than one iced immediately. |
| Ice it | A cooler with ice, not a bucket of lake water. Quality falls fast in a warm bucket, and this is the single biggest difference between panfish that taste good and panfish that do not. |
| Take a meal, not a limit | Especially on bluegill beds in June, where the big males you are catching are the ones guarding the nests. <i>see the Bluegill sheet</i> |
| Know the rules | Length and bag limits are per water body and change every year. Measure before you decide. <i>see the Seasonal Calendar sheet</i> |

Clean, drain, dry. Before you leave a landing: remove all weed and mud, drain the livewell, bilge and bait bucket, and never move live fish or lake water to another water body. Wisconsin enforces this. Invasive species and fish disease move on trailers, and once they are in a lake like Pine they do not come back out.

Teaching it

This is the sheet to work through before the first trip, not after the first fish. A child who is taught to wet their hands and keep the fish in the net will do it for the rest of their life without thinking about it; one who learns it after dropping a bass on a hot dock has already learnt the other thing.

Use a closed-loop check



Question	Check	Recovery
What changed?	Name one visible or measurable fact: wind direction, depth, water temperature, abrasion, knot shape, lure track, fish reflex, or elapsed time.	If you cannot name the change, observe for one minute before changing equipment.
What am I testing?	Change one variable only and state what success will look like before the attempt.	Restore the last known setup; avoid changing lure, depth, speed, and location together.
Is the system sound?	Trace the full chain from hand to fish: line, knot, leader, hook, drag, handling tool, route home.	Stop on any rough line, crossed wrap, open snap, dull point, missing tool, or unsafe condition; repair or leave.
What proves completion?	A repeatable result and a final tactile/visual check, not merely finishing the written steps.	Repeat slowly under good light. If the check is ambiguous, treat it as a failure.

Final proof before the next cast

Say the plan in one sentence. Tug-test the terminal connection, touch-check the last two feet of line, confirm hook point and snap closure, set the drag, and identify the safe landing and release route. If weather, visibility, footing, or fish condition makes that route doubtful, change the plan before casting.

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